

Car Repair & Vehicle Help

A broken-down car can mean a lost job. There's no single national "car repair grant," but charities, community agencies, and free recall repairs can get you back on the road. Below are the main national starting points. Tick the box once you've contacted each one.

⚠ BEFORE YOU START

Real car-repair help is free to apply for. Any website or caller charging a "registration" or "processing" fee to submit your application is a scam. Always get a written repair estimate from a licensed mechanic before applying.

1 Start Local — Fastest Help

Local agencies and 211 are usually the quickest route to repair help, gas cards, or a referral.

☐ 211 — Local Car Repair Help

Call or search to find local repair assistance, nonprofit garages, and emergency transportation help.

→ www.211.org or dial 211

☐ Community Action Agency — Find Yours

Local agencies may help with car repairs or transportation so you can keep working. Ask what's available.

→ communityactionpartnership.com/find-a-cap

2 Charities That Repair Cars

National nonprofits repair cars or partner with local mechanics for free or discounted work, usually for working families.

☐ Working Cars for Working Families (NCLC)

Publishes a national list of car-ownership and repair programs by area. The best place to find a local program.

→ www.workingcarsforworkingfamilies.org

☐ Free Charity Cars / 1-800-Charity Cars

The nation's oldest vehicle charity — also helps with essential repairs to make a car safe. Priority for domestic-abuse survivors, military families, and medical need.

→ www.800charitycars.org

☐ Catholic Charities & St. Vincent de Paul

Many local chapters help with car repairs or payments for working families. Call your local office.

→ www.catholiccharitiesusa.org/find-help

3 Free Safety-Recall Repairs

If your car has an open safety recall, the manufacturer must fix it for free — no income limit, any car owner.

☐ NHTSA — Check for Recalls

Enter your license plate or VIN to see open recalls. Recall repairs are always free at a dealer.

→ www.nhtsa.gov/recalls

4 Faith & Community Garages

Some churches and nonprofit garages do free or deeply discounted repairs for people who need a car for work.

☐ Local Church “Car Care” Ministries

Many churches run benevolence or car-care ministries. Call local churches or ask 211 for one near you.

→ Ask 211 or local churches

☐ Nonprofit Repair Garages

Some areas have garages offering 50–80% off for low-income workers. Search your city + “nonprofit auto repair.”

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⚠ WATCH OUT FOR

Government car-repair help is a top target for scams. Never pay a fee to apply, and don't trust a caller who “guarantees” a repair grant. Real programs are free and ask for proof of income and need.

★ A TIP THAT HELPS

Get a written, itemized estimate from a licensed mechanic first — most programs require it, and it helps you avoid being overcharged. Explain you need the car for work; many programs prioritize employment.

NEED HELP WHERE YOU LIVE?

Ask for your personalized car-repair search

This guide covers the main national starting points. For repair help, nonprofit garages, and transportation programs specific to your city or county, use the personalized AI search or ask in the Questions area, and we'll help you find the closest options.

MY NOTES — WHO I CALLED, WHEN, AND WHAT THEY SAID
